

UMS



the issues—and their announcement as early as the Railway Budget in February. Banerjee has constituted a high-powered committee to look into the issues and prepare a report. The committee is yet to start functioning. The gentle rap on Banerjee's knuckles was the prime minister's polite reminder to her, hinting that she should concentrate on the job entrusted to her instead of frittering away her energies on petty politics.

She may have declared the CPI(M) Government her enemy number one but it is quite churlish for her to expect that the Centre should share her feeling towards the Marxists. She seethed when Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee inaugurated a few projects in the state at the invitation of the state Government. Now, she is angry because the prime minister had asked

Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya to accompany him in his car when he visited the ailing Jyoti Basu in the hospital.

Banerjee complained to the prime minister that she was not informed about his visit and could not come to receive him at the airport. Sulking, she has decided to boycott two functions where Singh would share the dais with the chief minister. Her grievances extend beyond that. She is still simmering over the Centre sending paramilitary forces to help the state Government tackle the Naxals in Lalgarh and Jangalmahal without consulting her. Having shared a good rapport with the finance minister when she was preparing her Railway Budget, her animosity with him is putting the Government in an awkward spot. Mukherjee, a veteran from West Bengal and the interlocutor for Congress with Trinamool, has irked Banerjee for his continued good relations with the Bengal Marxists. The interaction between the two leaders has been minimal and strained after the railway minister expressed her "hurt and unhappiness".

After one particularly heated telephonic conversation between the two Bengal leaders, Banerjee complained that the finance minister had spoken "too harshly". She claimed that even her mother had not shouted at her the way he did. Mukherjee and Congress, on their part, are finding it difficult to handle her unpredictable behaviour. They were irked when Banerjee fielded 30 candidates in Arunachal Pradesh. "Arunachal Pradesh is a sensitive area. I don't know what message she is trying to send by fielding candidates against the Congress. We are trying to form a stable government there and her efforts will not help in that direction," Mukherjee is reported to have told the Congress leaders.

The unstoppable Banerjee has also made it clear that she is going to woo state Congress leaders to join her party in the run-up to the coming civic polls in West Bengal. She wants to strengthen her base in the state so that she is not too dependent on the Congress for Assembly elections next

Rebel Within

Banerjee has been at loggerheads with the Central Government on several issues

- After opposing the Government's Land Acquisition (Amendment) Bill, she came out with her own debatable policy for Railways.

- Her White Paper questioning Lalu Prasad Yadav's claims of a Railways' turnaround was an embarrassment for the UPA Government.

- She publicly criticised the Centre's decision to send paramilitary forces to help West Bengal in anti-Naxal joint operations.

- She does not want anyone from the UPA, be it Pranab Mukherjee or the prime minister, to maintain civil relations with the Left Front.

- In the Arunachal Pradesh Assembly elections, the Trinamool chief fielded 30 candidates against the Congress.

- She is trying to woo Congress members in West Bengal ahead of the state civic polls.